

"God's Mixed Feelings About Jewelry"

A sermon by Dr. Alexander Biscette

A Critical Review by Pastor Wentland Paul

Abstract

This review examines the hermeneutical method and exegetical claims of Dr. Alexander Biscette's sermon "God's Mixed Feelings About Jewelry." The sermon argues, from a survey of texts spanning Genesis to the Pastoral and General Epistles, that jewelry is morally neutral in itself and that scripture's censure falls on idolatrous disposition rather than on the object worn. This review finds that the argument presented for that conclusion does not hold under sustained examination. The sermon rests on a single controlling hermeneutic applied recursively across dissimilar texts rather than on the convergent, independent witnesses it presents itself as marshaling. That hermeneutic conflates divine forbearance with divine sanction in a manner that fails decisively when tested against the canon's legislation on royal polygamy. Several of the sermon's principal proof texts misidentify precious metal functioning as currency, bridewealth, or tribute as personal ornament, a conflation the sermon needs in order to make one motive-based principle appear to account for material that is substantially about wealth and status rather than adornment. The sermon's repeated disclaimers of judgment, further, sit uneasily beside an extended sequence of illustrative anecdotes that function rhetorically as mockery of the very appearances the sermon claims not to be judging. The cumulative effect is a sermon whose stated humility outpaces its actual argument and its actual rhetoric alike.

1. The Sermon's Governing Thesis and Method

Dr. Biscette's sermon presents itself as a canonical survey, moving sequentially through Genesis 24, Exodus 3 and 32, the Song of Songs, Ezekiel 16, Genesis 35, Isaiah 3, and the household codes of 1 Timothy 2 and 1 Peter 3. The cumulative impression is of a broad textual witness converging independently on a single conclusion. This impression does not survive scrutiny. The sermon's reading of every other passage is governed by a single interpretive judgment reached at Exodus 32: that the divine anger provoked by the golden calf was directed at the idol fashioned from gold rather than at the wearing of gold as such. This judgment, generalized into an operating principle, that the object is morally neutral and idolatrous disposition is the true locus of divine concern, is then imposed as a controlling lens on the remainder of the corpus. What the sermon presents as many independent witnesses is, on inspection, one interpretive key applied repeatedly to texts it has not been shown to fit. The persuasive weight of forty minutes of preaching rests, in the end, on a single unexamined inference.

2. The One Argument in the Sermon With Genuine Force

The sermon's single piece of load-bearing reasoning is the argument constructed around Israel's wilderness sojourn. Dr. Biscette observes that the divine presence, manifest in the pillar of cloud and the pillar of fire, accompanied Israel continuously from Egypt to Sinai, and that the covenant at Sinai was ratified while the people still wore the gold and silver taken from the Egyptians per Exodus 3:22. Unlike the golden calf reading, this argument does not depend on a contestable interpretation of a single narrative crux; it reasons from an uncontested premise to a conclusion about the wilderness period specifically. It is worth isolating for that reason: it is the one place in the

sermon where the reasoning does not immediately dissolve into assertion. It is also, as the following section demonstrates, insufficient to establish the conclusion the sermon builds on it.

3. Methodological Failure: Forbearance Misread as Sanction

The wilderness argument depends on an inference that does not hold: that sustained divine presence during a practice constitutes evidence that the practice carried no prior prohibition. This is *argumentum ex silentio* in its plainest form, an argument from the absence of recorded censure to the presence of approval, and scripture supplies the term that dismantles it directly. In Acts 17:30, Paul characterizes God as having "overlooked" (*hyperidon*) the times of ignorance, a term denoting forbearance under a standing moral reality, not the suspension of that reality. A sermon built on this inference has mistaken God's patience for God's permission, and the mistake is not a minor one, since the entire wilderness argument, and by extension a substantial share of the sermon's persuasive weight, depends on it.

The failure is not hypothetical. Applying the sermon's own inferential method to a case where scripture supplies the independent warrant it lacks for jewelry exposes the problem without ambiguity. Deuteronomy 17:17 legislates against a king multiplying wives and states the rationale in advance: "lest his heart turn away." The statute predates David and Solomon. David dances before the ark in 2 Samuel 6 already married to multiple wives, and Solomon presides at the temple's dedication in 1 Kings 8 with his own household already in violation of the same statute. If the sermon's inference were sound, this narrative silence would prove the practice uncensured. It proves nothing of the kind, because the prohibition is textually antecedent and demonstrably in force throughout. The sequence resolves in 1 Kings 11:4, where the narrator states plainly that Solomon's wives "turned away his heart," the exact outcome Deuteronomy had named as the danger. Sustained divine engagement coexisted, in this case beyond dispute, with an active prohibition being violated in real time. The wilderness argument, tested against a case that actually supplies a control, fails. There is no reason remaining to trust the same inference where the sermon applies it to jewelry, absent the corroboration it has just been shown to require and does not have.

4. Exegetical Failure: Currency Misread as Ornament

A second, independent defect runs beneath the sermon's treatment of precious metal, which it reads uniformly as personal adornment despite clear indicators, both philological and historical, that several of its central texts describe currency, bridewealth, or tribute instead. Prior to coinage, silver and gold circulated in the ancient Near East as *hacksilver*, weighed and often cut fragments valued by mass, a practice already attested in Genesis 23:16. The sermon shows no awareness of this distinction, and the omission is not trivial, since it is precisely what allows several of the sermon's anchor texts to be misread as supporting its thesis.

In Genesis 24, the personal token given to Rebekah in verse 22 is distinct from the transaction in verse 53, where silver, gold, and garments are given to her brother and mother, a transfer that conforms to *mohar*, bridewealth sealing a marriage contract, not an expression of aesthetic regard. In Exodus 3:22, the "articles of silver and gold" more plausibly denote portable, liquid wealth functioning as compensation for centuries of unremunerated labor than an endorsement of ornament, a reading confirmed by the fact that the same material subsequently supplies both the tabernacle's furnishings in Exodus 25 and the golden calf in Exodus 32, a dual use intelligible only if the metal was handled throughout as convertible bullion. In Exodus 32:2, Aaron's request for "the gold rings in your ears" targets

the people's most available store of transferable wealth, not an interest in ornament; what follows is the conversion of communal wealth into an idol, an act of misappropriation the sermon flattens into a lapse in personal taste. In Isaiah 3:18–23, the catalogue of ornaments to be removed from the daughters of Zion targets an economic elite whose visible wealth is implicated in the injustice Isaiah names in the surrounding oracle at 3:14–15, not adornment considered apart from its social function, a point the sermon gestures toward without following through because the logical extension of negating ornament prohibition would be untenable since it naturally leads to the aforementioned. Thus the ornament generated a self-exaltation which was emphasized; complementing the inclusion of ornament prohibition for adornment use. The sermon treats none of these distinctions. It needs the collapse of currency into ornament for its single motive-based principle to appear to account for the range of material it surveys, and the collapse does not survive contact with the texts on their own terms.

5. Rhetorical Failure: Disclaimed Judgment, Practiced Mockery

The sermon repeats, at intervals, that it does not intend to judge anyone for what they wear. That disclaimer does not describe the sermon's actual rhetorical conduct. Dr. Biscette recounts, at length and for evident comic effect, encountering a woman he compares to "the woman of Revelation 17," describes a fellow minister's culture shock at a casually dressed church leader as severe enough to warrant an ambulance, mocks a seminary student's hairstyle and its accompanying ornaments before an entire congregation, and characterizes certain shoes and cars as resembling products of "Aaron's oven," a direct comparison to the golden calf. Each of these anecdotes is delivered as entertainment, met by the recorded laughter of the congregation, and each targets precisely the outward appearance the sermon insists is not the proper object of judgment. A sermon cannot credibly disclaim judgment on appearance while building its most memorable material out of ridicule of appearance. The disclaimer functions, whether intentionally or not, as rhetorical cover, permission to make the judgment while denying that judgment is being made. This is not a minor stylistic tic. It is a direct contradiction between the sermon's stated thesis and its operative content, and it should weigh against any assessment of the sermon's pastoral achievement, not merely its exegetical rigor.

6. Conclusion

Dr. Biscette's sermon does not accomplish what it sets out to do. Its single argument with genuine independent force, the wilderness reasoning, fails once tested against a case scripture addresses with an explicit, antecedent prohibition, and the failure is not incidental but structural, since the same inferential error underwrites the sermon's treatment of the golden calf as well. Its exegesis of the currency-bearing texts substitutes a category, ornament, for the one the texts actually supply, wealth, tribute, and status, and does so as a precondition for its thesis rather than as a considered reading of each passage. And its professed refusal to judge anyone by appearance is repeatedly and knowingly undercut by its own choice of illustrative material. What remains, once the argument is examined rather than simply followed, is a conclusion asserted with considerably more confidence than the sermon has earned for it.